

WHAT IS LOVE?

In her famous poem “How do I love thee? Let me count the ways . . .,” English poet Elizabeth Barrett Browning (1806–1861) expresses the wide variety of feelings she has for her partner. The English language uses the word *love* to describe not only this romantic love but all of the other ways there are to love. So, let’s count the ways . . .

FOLLOW YOUR HEART



“ALL YOU NEED IS LOVE.”

John Lennon (1940–1980) and Paul McCartney (1942–), British songwriters

FALLING IN LOVE

When a couple falls in love, they share an intensity of emotions that includes passion (sexual attraction), intimacy (close friendship and the exchange of secrets), and commitment (the shared desire to stay together). According to biologists, they are fulfilling their natural drive to have children and pass on their genes to the next generation. Cue the violins . . .



ABSTRACT AFFECTION

Another type of love is when people identify their own happiness with an abstract idea or cause, such as their country, freedom, or a favorite charity. The attachment can run very deep—try asking a football fan how he feels when his team loses!



ANIMAL ATTRACTION

Keeping animals as pets can give people a source of love and companionship, especially for those living alone. Doctors say that petting animals releases feel-good hormones and reduces stress levels. If you are lucky enough, swimming with dolphins will produce a similar effect!